

ICD and Pacemaker Symptoms and Questions - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1494 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- Adult safety assessment for symptoms associated with an implanted pacemaker or implantable cardioverter-defibrillator (ICD), including shock events, arrhythmia symptoms, and implant-site complications.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [OPEN_TEXT] Is this a pacemaker, ICD, or other implanted cardiac device, and when and where was it implanted or last checked? Use the device card if available without delaying care.
2. [OPEN_TEXT] Did the device deliver a shock? Record how many shocks, when they occurred, whether shocks are continuing, and symptoms before and after each shock.
3. [YES_NO] Is there collapse or near-collapse, chest pain, breathing difficulty, palpitations, severe dizziness, confusion, or persistent weakness now?
4. [YES_NO] Is the implant site newly red, hot, swollen, open, draining blood, pus, or clear fluid, or associated with fever or chills?
5. [YES_NO] Has anyone placed a magnet over the device, attempted to reprogram it, or manipulated the generator or leads? Do not do so.

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Heart Rate and Heartbeat Questions

Are palpitations or heartbeat questions present without an implanted-device concern?

Heartbeat concerns without an implanted-device issue belong in the Heart Rate and Heartbeat Questions pathway.

1. Disposition level 100

Is there collapse or near-collapse, chest pain, severe breathing difficulty, sustained or distressing palpitations, severe dizziness, confusion, pale/blue/grey skin, a shock with ongoing symptoms, more than one ICD shock, or continuing shocks?

These features may represent an unstable arrhythmia, cardiac event, device problem, or electrical storm. Repeated ICD shocks or any shock with ongoing symptoms require immediate emergency assessment.

1. Disposition level 70

If no emergency feature is present, was there one ICD shock followed by full recovery, are palpitations, dizziness, breathlessness, or prior symptoms recurring, or is the implant site red, hot, swollen, painful, open, or draining, with or without fever or chills?

A single ICD shock still requires prompt device-team review, and recurrent symptoms or implant-site infection may require device interrogation, rhythm assessment, or treatment. The exact Qatar device-clinic route and timeframe are governance-required.

1. Disposition level 15

Is this only a non-urgent device question with no shock, cardiac symptom, wound change, fever, or other feature above?

Device-specific restrictions and expected recovery depend on device type, indication, implant date, manufacturer, and implanting team's instructions; telephone triage should defer to the governance-approved device service.

Advice

Emergency ICD or pacemaker precautions

- Call Qatar 999 now. Sit or lie in a safe place, keep another person nearby if possible, and do not drive. Do not place a magnet over the device, attempt programming, manipulate the generator or leads, or touch the patient during an active shock. Follow the 999 call-handler's instructions; begin resuscitation if directed if the patient becomes unresponsive and is not breathing normally. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: another shock, collapse, chest pain, severe palpitations, or worsening breathing; unresponsiveness or abnormal breathing.

Prompt device-clinic or in-person review

- Use the Qatar governance-approved device-clinic or in-person pathway; the exact service and timeframe are not defined by this UAT protocol. Keep the device identification card and shock details available. Do not drive after a shock or while symptomatic, and do not apply magnets or manipulate the device. Keep an affected implant wound clean and dry without squeezing or probing it.
- Call Back If: another shock, fainting, chest pain, breathing difficulty, sustained palpitations, or severe dizziness; spreading redness, wound opening or drainage, fever, or chills.

Governance-approved device advice

- Use the Qatar governance-approved device service for individualized advice. Follow the implanting team's written instructions for activity, wound care, driving, medicines, electromagnetic exposure, and follow-up; this UAT protocol does not set universal time limits.
- Call Back If: shock, fainting, chest pain, breathing difficulty, palpitations, fever, or wound change.

First aid

- Call Qatar 999 now. Sit or lie in a safe place, keep another person nearby if possible, and do not drive. Do not place a magnet over the device, attempt programming, manipulate the generator or leads, or touch the patient

during an active shock. Follow the 999 call-handler's instructions; begin resuscitation if directed if the patient becomes unresponsive and is not breathing normally. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.

References

- NHS.UK, "Pacemaker implantation", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/pacemaker-implantation/> (page last reviewed 30 March 2026)
- Mid and South Essex NHS Foundation Trust, "Pacemaker and ICD patients", <https://www.mse.nhs.uk/pacemaker-and-icd-patients/> (accessed 25 July 2026)
- American Heart Association, "Living With Your Implantable Cardioverter Defibrillator (ICD)", <https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/arrhythmia/prevention--treatment-of-arrhythmia/living-with-your-implantable-cardioverter-defibrillator-icd> (accessed 25 July 2026)
- Qatar Ministry of Public Health, "Healthcare Services in Qatar", <https://sportandhealth.moph.gov.qa/EN/faninfo/Pages/HealthcareServicesInQatar.aspx> (999 ambulance access; accessed 25 July 2026)

Provenance

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